



The Xerox Alto – birth of the GUI

start working on something similar right away, and thus began the story of the Macintosh. Jobs wanted people to be as comfortable with computers as they would be, say driving a car, or using a can opener. He wanted the process to be as intuitive as possible. He wanted the interaction between man and his creation to be friendly. The tales of his obsession over minor design elements are legendary. The release date of the Macintosh had to be pushed back several months because Steve Jobs wanted the computer monitor to look as close to a human head as possible. He wanted the calculator application on the Macintosh to look as close to a real life calculator as possible, complete with clickable buttons. The engineers at Apple, exasperated, had to make a “design your own calculator” kit just so that Jobs could get the shape, size, and contours just right.

The Apple Macintosh revolutionized the personal computer market, and with the weight of any revolution comes ideological inertia. For many years hence, skeuomorphic design dominated the world of personal computers, and smartphones after that. At its best, skeuomorphic design was delightfully tacky. There was a skewed brilliance in the